“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 11

The Departure of Haridāsa Ṭhākura

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I bow to Haridāsa and to his Lord, Caitanya, who took Haridāsa’s body on His lap after he had departed, and danced.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to the all-merciful Lord! Glory to Him who is dear to Advaita and dear to Nityānanda!

3 Glory to the Lord of Śrīnivāsa, the master of Haridāsa! Glory to Him who is dear to Gadādhara, the Lord of Svarūpa’s life!

4 Glory to Him who is dear to Kāśīśvara, the Lord of Jagadānanda’s life! Glory to the Lord of Rūpa, Sanātana and Raghunātha!

5 Glory to Kṛṣṇa of golden form, the Supreme Lord Himself! O Lord, be merciful and grant me the shelter of Your feet.

6 Glory to Nityānandacandra, the life of Caitanya! Grant me devotion to Your lotus feet.

7 Glory to Advaitacandra, whom Caitanya honors! Glory to Advaitācārya! Grant me devotion to Your feet.

8 Glory to all the devotees of Gaura, whose very life is Gaura! All you devotees, together grant me devotion.

9 Glory to Rūpa, Sanātana, Jīva, Raghunātha, Raghunātha and Gopāla! These six are the lords of my life.

10 By the mercy of all of them I write of Caitanya's pastimes and qualities. However I may write, I do it to purify myself.

11 Thus Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala, enjoying the pastimes of kīrtana with His devotees.

12 By day He danced and sang kīrtana and beheld Lord Jagannātha; by night He relished rasa with Rāya and Svarūpa.

13 So Mahāprabhu's days passed happily, and in His body many transformations of separation from Kṛṣṇa appeared.

14 Day by day these transformations grew, and at night they became intense: anxiety, agitation, delirious talk and all the others the scriptures describe.

15 Svarūpa Gosāñi and Rāmānanda Rāya, the two of them, attended the Lord day and night.

16 One day Govinda took mahā-prasāda and joyfully went to give it to Haridāsa.

17 He saw that Haridāsa Ṭhākura was lying down, very slowly chanting his fixed number of names.

18 Govinda said, "Get up, come and eat." Haridāsa replied, "Today I shall fast.

19 My counted chanting is not complete; how can I eat? Yet you have brought mahā-prasāda; how can I disregard it?"

20 Saying this, he bowed down to the mahā-prasāda, took a single particle (*rañca*) of it and ate it.

21 The next day Mahāprabhu came to him and asked, “Haridāsa, are you well?”

22 He bowed down and submitted, “My body is well, but my mind and intelligence are not.”

23 The Lord said, “What is the illness? Tell Me exactly.” He said, “I cannot complete my counted chanting.”

24 The Lord said, “You have grown old; reduce your number. You are perfect in body; why are you so intent on sādhana?

25 You have descended to deliver the people, and you have preached the glory of the holy name in the world.

26 Now reduce your number and perform saṅkīrtana.” Haridāsa said, “Please hear my submission.

27 I was born in a low caste, and my body is contemptible. I am given to low deeds — I am the lowest of wretches.

28 I am unfit to be seen or touched, yet You accepted me. You snatched me out of the hell of Raurava and raised me up to Vaikuṇṭha.

29 You are the independent Lord and act as You will. You make the world dance — each one as You please.

30 By Your grace You have made me dance in many ways: though a *mleccha*, I ate the *śrāddha* plate meant for brāhmaṇas.

31 For many days I have had one desire. My heart tells me that You will soon wind up Your pastimes.

32 Lord, never let me see that pastime. Let my body fall before You.

33 I shall hold Your lotus feet to my heart and gaze with my eyes upon Your moonlike face.

34 With my tongue I shall utter Your name, “Kṛṣṇa Caitanya.” This is my desire — to give up my life in this way.

35 If by Your grace this desire of mine may come true, then grant this request of mine, O merciful Lord.

36 Let this low body of mine fall before You. The fulfillment of this desire depends on You alone.”

37 The Lord said, “Haridāsa, whatever you ask, merciful Kṛṣṇa will surely grant.

38 But whatever happiness I have, I have it all with you. It is not fitting for you to go away and leave Me.”

39 Clasping His feet, Haridāsa said, “Do not show me *māyā*! Lord, surely show this fallen one this mercy (*dayā*).

40 There are so many great souls, crest jewels far above me; millions of devotees assist in Your pastimes.

41 If one insect like me dies and is gone, what is lost? When an ant dies, what loss does the earth suffer?

42 You are affectionate to Your devotees (*bhakata-vatsala*), and I am a mere semblance of a devotee. Surely, Lord, You will fulfil this hope of mine."

43 The Lord then went to perform His midday duties, promising that the next day, after seeing Jagannātha, He would come to give Haridāsa His darśana.

44 Mahāprabhu embraced him and went to the sea to perform His midday duties.

45 In the morning, after seeing Jagannātha, He hurried with all the devotees to see Haridāsa.

46 Coming before Haridāsa, the Lord gave him darśana, and Haridāsa bowed to the feet of the Lord and of the Vaiṣṇavas.

47 The Lord said, "Haridāsa, what news?" Haridāsa said, "Lord, as You command."

48 In the courtyard the Lord began a great saṅkīrtana, in which Vakreśvara Paṇḍita danced.

49 Svarūpa Gosāñi and all the Lord's other associates surrounded Haridāsa and sang the holy name.

50 Before Rāmānanda, Sārvabhauma and all the others, the Lord began to speak of Haridāsa's qualities.

51 As He told of Haridāsa's qualities, the Lord became as if five-mouthed, and the more He spoke, the greater His joy grew.

52 Haridāsa's qualities filled everyone's mind with wonder, and all the devotees bowed to his feet.

53 Haridāsa seated the Lord in front of himself and fixed his eyes, like two bees, on the lotus of His face.

54 He brought the Lord's feet to his heart and held them there; the dust of the feet of all the devotees adorned his head.

55 Again and again he said, "Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Prabhu!" He drank in the sweetness of the Lord's face, and streams of tears flowed from his eyes.

56 While uttering the words "Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya," he sent his life-air out of the body together with the name.

57 Like a great master of yoga, he departed at his own will, and everyone remembered the departure of Bhīṣma.

58 Everyone raised a tumult with the sounds "Hari!" and "Kṛṣṇa!", and Mahāprabhu was overwhelmed with the bliss of love.

59 Lifting Haridāsa's body onto His lap, the Lord danced in the courtyard, absorbed in love.

60 The Lord's ecstasy overpowered all the devotees; absorbed in love, they all danced and sang kīrtana.

61 In this way the Lord danced for some time; then Svarūpa Gosāñi made a request to Him.

62 Then they placed Haridāsa Ṭhākura on a *vimāna*, a palanquin shaped like a celestial chariot, and carried him to the sea, singing kīrtana.

63 Mahāprabhu went in front, dancing all the way, and behind Him Vakreśvara danced with the devotees.

64 He bathed Haridāsa in the water of the sea and said, “This sea has now become a great holy place (*mahā-tīrtha*).”

65 The devotees drank the water that had washed Haridāsa’s feet, and they anointed his body with sandal paste that was prasāda.

66 They placed on his body *ḍora* (silk cords), *kaḍāra* (sandal paste), prasāda and cloth; then, making a pit in the sand, they laid him in it.

67 On all sides the devotees sang kīrtana, and Vakreśvara Paṇḍita danced in bliss.

68 Calling “Hari bol! Hari bol!”, Gaurarāya Himself put sand on Haridāsa’s body with His holy hands.

69 When they had covered him with sand, they had a platform built over him and a great enclosure made around it.

70 Then Mahāprabhu sang kīrtana and danced, and the tumult of Hari’s name filled the world.

71 Then Mahāprabhu bathed in the sea with all the devotees and joyfully played in the water.

72 After circumambulating Haridāsa, He came to the Lion Gate, and the tumult of Hari’s kīrtana filled the whole city.

73 Coming to the Lion Gate, the Lord spread out the end of His cloth before the shopkeepers and begged them for prasāda:

74 “I am begging prasāda for the festival of Haridāsa Ṭhākura. Please give Me alms.”

75 Hearing this, all the shopkeepers joyfully lifted up their big baskets (*cāṅgaḍā*) and came to give prasāda.

76 Svarūpa Gosāñi stopped them, and the shopkeepers sat down again in their shops with their baskets.

77 Svarūpa Gosāñi sent the Lord home and kept with him four Vaiṣṇavas and four porters (*pichāḍā*).

78 Svarūpa Gosāñi said to all the shopkeepers, “Give me one *puñjā* (a portion counted by fours) of each item.”

79 In this way he had all kinds of prasāda tied into bundles, put them on the heads of the four men and brought them back.

80 Vāṇīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka brought prasāda, and Kāśī Miśra sent a great deal of prasāda.

81 The Lord seated all the Vaiṣṇavas in rows and, with four helpers, began to serve them Himself.

82 A small amount would not come into Mahāprabhu’s holy hand: on each leaf He served enough food for five.

83 Svarūpa said, “Lord, sit down and watch. I shall serve with these helpers.”

84 Svarūpa, Jagadānanda, Kāśīśvara and Śaṅkara — these four served without pause.

85 Since the Lord had not eaten, no one would eat. That day the Lord had an invitation from Kāśī Miśra.

86 Kāśī Miśra came himself with prasāda and insistently had the Lord take His meal.

87 The Lord took His meal with Purī and Bhāratī, and then all the Vaiṣṇavas ate.

88 He had them eat until they were filled to the throat, the Lord repeating, “Give more! Give more!”

89 When everyone had eaten and performed *ācamana*, the Lord adorned them all with garlands and sandal paste.

90 Absorbed in love, the Lord bestowed a boon, and hearing it, the devotees’ hearts were fulfilled.

91–93 “Whoever saw the festival of Haridāsa’s departure, whoever danced here or sang kīrtana, whoever went to put sand on him, and whoever among them ate at the festival — all of them will soon attain Kṛṣṇa. Such is the power of seeing Haridāsa.

94 Out of mercy Kṛṣṇa gave Me his company. Kṛṣṇa’s will is independent: now He has broken that company.

95 When Haridāsa wished to go, My power could not keep him.

96 By his mere wish he sent his life out of his body, just as we have heard of Bhīṣma’s departure long ago.

97 Haridāsa was the crest jewel of the earth; without him the earth has been robbed of its jewel.

98 “Call out ‘Glory, glory to Haridāsa!’ and raise the sound of Hari’s name!” Saying this, Mahāprabhu Himself began to dance.

99 Everyone sang, “Glory, glory, glory to Haridāsa, who revealed the glory of the holy name!”

100 Then Mahāprabhu bade farewell to all the devotees and rested, in both joy and sorrow.

101 Thus I have told of Haridāsa’s departure (*vijaya*); by hearing of it one gains firm devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

102 From this we know Caitanya’s affection for His devotees: He, the crest jewel of sannyāsīs, fulfilled His devotee’s desire.

103 At his last hour the Lord let him see and touch Him, and taking him on His lap, He Himself danced.

104 In His mercy He Himself put sand on him with His holy hands, and He Himself begged prasāda and held a great festival.

105 Haridāsa was a *mahā-bhāgavata* and supremely learned (*parama-vidvān*); for the sake of this good fortune he departed first.

106 These deeds of Caitanya are an ocean of nectar; a single drop of it satisfies the ears and the mind.

107 Whoever has set his heart on crossing the ocean of worldly existence should hear with faith this account of Caitanya.

108 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.